me to lie on the back seat for a while. The driver was shocked to see me in that state, to say the least. As Atul stood outside explaining to him what had happened, I got onto the seat and lay flat for a good five minutes. Never in my life had I imagined I'd be doing such a thing just a few minutes from my house, at 6 a.m.! When I was feeling a little better we thanked the rickshaw driver profusely for his help, paid him a hundred rupees and started slowly cycling back down the hill. By now Faisal, at the foot of the hill, was getting impatient, because he thought we must be drinking tea at the top, and he was stunned to hear what had happened. However, none of this deterred me from continuing with my training ahead of what turned out to be my last few months in international cricket.

I had announced my retirement from the IPL in May 2013 and this was to be my last Champions League. To my great satisfaction, the Mumbai Indians won the trophy, beating Rajasthan Royals in the final, and it meant my team had won both the IPL and the Champions League in my last season as a player. We had gelled well as a team and Rohit Sharma did well as captain.

It was during the Champions League campaign that, for the first time in my career, I found I had to force myself to go to the gym. It was also the first time in my career that I didn't feel bad about missing a session. Now, it wasn't as if I hit the gym every day of my career. I have always tended to train in bursts, before taking a break for a few days. But this was the first time that I just did not feel like pushing myself. I was also taking far longer to recover from injuries and was feeling a number of aches and pains.

India's next scheduled Tests were in South Africa in December 2013 and that's where I was expecting to play my 200th Test match. After that, there was an away series in New Zealand in early 2014 and I was looking forward to both tours. A number of my friends had discussed the 200th Test match with me and made plans to travel to South Africa to watch me reach this milestone. In fact, I had to keep reminding Ajit to book his tickets. But then the BCCI announced that there would be a two-Test home series against the West Indies at the beginning of November 2013 and I had to rethink my plans. It was then, and I don't know exactly how and when, that the thought of retirement first came to me. I started to wonder whether those two Tests against the West Indies should be my last.